

Women should start charging consultation fees.

Because somewhere along the way we became unpaid translators, therapists, detectives, customer care representatives, hostage negotiators, and emotional rehabilitation centers for grown men.

I am tired.

Not the "I need a nap" kind of tired. Not the "nitarudi maeneo later" kind of exhausted either.

I am talking about the kind of tired where you realize you've been carrying an entire relationship on your back like a sack of cement while the person beside you keeps asking if you're sure it's heavy.

Do you know what I find fascinating about human beings?

Actually, men.

No, no. Human beings.

...No. Men.

Because every time I try to make this argument gender neutral, a man somewhere appears in the DM to say, "Not all men."

Relax, boss.

If it isn't about you, congratulations. You survived another article. Take your trophy and go.

Now where was I?

Ah yes.

Translation.

Somewhere between girlhood and adulthood, women in this country are handed a dictionary nobody remembers writing. Suddenly we are expected to become fluent in Male.

"Oh, he didn't text back all day because he's overwhelmed with work."

"He wasn't being cold when he walked into the house and ignored you. That's simply how he communicates when he's stressed."

"He didn't forget your anniversary. He's been busy with business."

"He isn't emotionally unavailable or playing games. He's processing."

"He doesn't want a relationship, because he was hurt or he's just not ready, but he wants to have me all to himself cause he cares and that shows he will one day be ready. So let me be loyal to him and wait."

Ladies, at this point I could qualify as a UN interpreter.

I have translated silence into stress.

Distance into burnout.

Bare minimum "Okay" and "lol" and yes. Lol! Use emojis for goodness sake. Or write "haha". All those texts into "he's probably tired from the commute."

Unexplained disappearances over the weekend into "maybe his phone died."

Entire personality changes into "maybe something happened at work."

I deserve a pension.

At the very least a retirement party.

Maybe even Employee of the Month.

The sheer amount of unpaid psychological labor I have performed in these streets should qualify as government service.

Nobody talks about what that translation work does to your physical body. The clenched jaw you hold while forcing your voice into a gentle, non-threatening register so his ego doesn't bruise. The tension in your shoulders as you unclench your teeth late at night. The heavy, suffocating weight in your chest when you go to sleep carrying the conflict alone, while the person who caused it sleeps soundly because you swallowed your own feelings just to keep the peace.

Not too long ago, side eye, I discovered that something I had said had genuinely hurt someone.

Now here's the funny part.

I didn't even agree with their interpretation.

I genuinely sat there thinking, Really? That hurt you? That tiny, basic statement?

But guess what happened next.

I apologized.

Immediately.

Not because I thought I was wrong.

Not because I suddenly agreed.

Because they were hurt.

Not once did it cross my mind to tell them they were overreacting.

Not once did I ask them to submit evidence proving they had a right to feel hurt.

Not once did I explain why their interpretation was technically incorrect.

Because the moment I learned they were hurt, being right stopped mattering.

See, that's the part I don't think enough people understand.

Empathy does not require agreement.

I don't have to write a thesis understanding your pain before deciding it matters.

If you tell me something I said hurt you, my first instinct isn't to build a PowerPoint presentation explaining why your feelings are objectively incorrect.

My first instinct is...

"Oh.

I'm sorry."

Crazy concept, I know.

Groundbreaking, really.

And then...

My brain started doing what women's brains have apparently been employed to do since the beginning of time.

Translate.

Investigate.

Absolve.

Maybe it wasn't the words.

Maybe it was the tone.

Maybe they were already overwhelmed.

Maybe something else happened that day.

Maybe...

Maybe...

Maybe...

Ei, ladies.

Why are we detectives?

Why are we conducting emotional CSI investigations every single time a man has a feeling?

Why are we analyzing his childhood, his attachment style, his boss, his workload, whether Manchester United lost, whether his barber pushed his hairline back, whether Mercury is in retrograde, and whether he skipped lunch...

...just to justify why he spoke to us like trash?

Now let me tell you what usually happens when the roles are reversed.

"Ah, you know I didn't mean it that way."

"You're overthinking things as usual."

"Wewe uko too sensitive."

"That's not what I said. Stop twisting my words."

"I don't understand why you'd feel that way. It wasn't a big deal."

"Aah, why are you bringing up stuff from last week?"

"Your story or your version, doesn't make any sense to me."

Interesting, isn't it?

Someone else's hurt receives instant empathy, soft tones, and a six paragraph apology.

A woman's hurt receives a cross examination.

Suddenly we're in a High Court session.

"Can you provide Exhibit A?"

"On what exact date did your feelings become injured?"

"Were there any witnesses present when I didn't text back?"

"Have you considered that you're simply dramatic?"

"Could you point to the section of the Constitution where your feelings were violated?"

Objection.

Sustained.

Dismissed.

I am furious.

Then there is this myth about honesty.

Apparently men love honest, straightforward women.

They preach it on social media every day.

"I just want a woman who keeps it real."

Until the honesty is about them.

Then suddenly you're mean.

Aggressive.

Hard to manage.

Too self aware. Yes. Some human told me that.

Tell the truth kindly?

Mean.

Have standards for how you want to be treated?

Intimidating.

Say a firm no without adding three laughing emojis?

Attitude.

Refuse to giggle through complete nonsense or smile through disrespect?

Masculine.

Cold.

Some of you call a woman mean simply because you've confused obedience with kindness.

Those two things are not the same.

We are constantly preached to about "softness" and "soft life," but the world doesn't actually want soft women. It wants quiet women. It wants a shock absorber. It wants a woman who is soft enough to absorb every impact, but hard enough to never complain about the damage.

I do not exist on this earth to cushion every sentence so your ego lands softly on memory foam.

Sometimes the truth arrives wearing steel toed boots.

She isn't trying to kill you.

She's trying to tell you something.

And before somebody clears their throat in my DM's to remind me that "women also hurt men"...

Congratulations, Sherlock.

You've discovered human beings.

The difference is that women are expected to become historians, therapists, linguists, customer care representatives, and hostage negotiators every time a man's feelings are slightly grazed.

We're expected to investigate his upbringing, his job stress, his family dynamics, his exes, Mercury being in retrograde, and whether he skipped lunch before deciding whether we have a right to be upset.

Meanwhile, some of us say,

"Hey... that hurt me."

And somehow we end up defending the fact that it hurt.

Sometimes we even end up apologizing for being hurt in the first place.

Do you know what's funny?

The women who become the best translators are usually the women nobody ever bothers to translate.

The women who spend years understanding everyone else are often the least understood people in the room.

Imagine speaking everybody's language while nobody ever learns yours.

Imagine becoming fluent in everyone's emotional dialect while the only response to yours is,

"You're overreacting."

That isn't emotional intelligence.

That's loneliness.

I am done.

Tired of translating.

Tired of explaining.

Tired of shrinking my reactions until they are convenient enough for someone else to digest without choking.

I am tired of giving people the benefit of every imaginable, ridiculous doubt while my own feelings are treated like suspicious activity.

Here is what I have decided.

If your feelings deserve compassion before they deserve an explanation...

Mine do too.

If your intentions don't erase my pain...

Mine don't erase yours either.

If I can apologize for hurting someone without first demanding proof that their pain was reasonable...

You can do the exact same thing for me.

That isn't radical.

That isn't feminism.

That isn't female privilege.

That is called meeting another human being where they are instead of where your ego wishes they were.

And frankly?

The translation bureau is officially closed. Kama huelewi, hiyo ni shida yako.